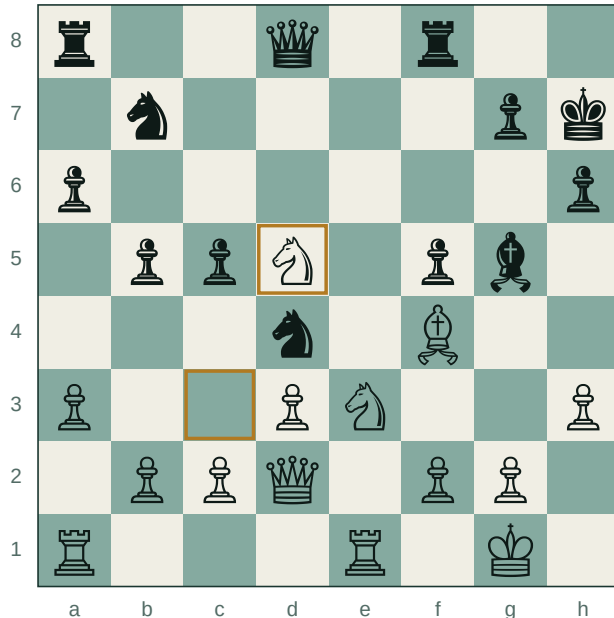


Clearance tactics: Black, move 21

Clearance tactics

Black to move



Previous move: 21.Ncd5. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

21...Bxf4 22. Nxf4 Qg5 23. Qd1 Qxf4

21...Bxf4 The bishop captures the bishop on f4. Recorded reply: **22.Nxf4**.

22...Qg5 The queen moves from d8 to g5. Recorded reply: **23.Qd1**.

23...Qxf4 The queen captures the knight on f4.

At the end, nominal material is White 29 / Black 31 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from -1 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Opening a line helps only if your next move is timely. The defender may close the line or create a stronger threat.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A clearance move vacates a square or opens a line for another piece. The clearing piece may sacrifice itself to gain the time needed for the follow-up.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the rook, bishop, queen, or knight that needs access, then locate the friendly piece blocking its route or destination.

The defending king is on g1. Geometrically undefended: queen on d2. Check for tactical protection.